EXPERIMENTAL PAPER BLUEPRINT

A reusable planning worksheet for empirical / review papers

This worksheet helps you design a personal blueprint for your next research paper. Work through the steps below, then keep the completed table as a template you can reuse it will drastically cut your planning time on future papers.

How to use this worksheet

1. Check the average length of comparable papers on a similar topic or in the same journal look for papers close to yours in methodology.

Comparable paper	Length (excl. references)
Paper 1	
Paper 2	
Paper 3	
Paper 4	
Paper 5	
Average	

2. Adjust the overall suggested length using that average.
3. Adjust the length of each section based on the papers you reviewed.
4. Check which sections are used in your field and edit the table accordingly:
   - Which sections from the table are present? Delete any that aren't.
   - Is there a separate literature review section?
   - Are results and discussion one section, or two?
   - Are discussion and conclusion one section, or two?

5. Compare the elements listed in each section against papers in your field:
   - Are all the listed elements present? Delete any that aren't.
   - Are they presented in the same order? If not, reorder the table.

6. Save the completed table below as its own document — this becomes your personal blueprint for future empirical papers.

Blueprint

Suggested overall length	Recommended range	Average length in my field
Benchmark	6000 – 10 000 words (without references)	

Section	Element	Purpose	In my field?	My notes and ideas
Introduction *500 – 1000 words*	Importance of the topic	*Introduce the topic and outline why it should be studied*	☐ Yes ☐ No	
	Brief literature review	*Situate your study within the context of your field*	☐ Yes ☐ No	
	Research gap	*Provide justification for your study*	☐ Yes ☐ No	
	Research aim	*Present what your study was about*	☐ Yes ☐ No	
	The main contributions of the paper (optional)	*Highlight what novel insights your study offers*	☐ Yes ☐ No	
	Structure of the paper (optional)	*Present the organization of the paper*	☐ Yes ☐ No	
Literature Review *optional · 1000 – 1500 words*	Definitions of key concepts	*Provide any necessary definitions of contested terms important in your research*	☐ Yes ☐ No	
	Key themes from the literature	*Outline the literature on the main topics related to your research*	☐ Yes ☐ No	
	Critical analysis	*Analyze previous studies critically to reinforce the research gap*	☐ Yes ☐ No	
Theoretical Framework *optional · 200 – 500 words*	The theories utilized in the study	*Present which theories you drew upon when designing the study and/or analyzing the data*	☐ Yes ☐ No	
Methodology *1000 – 1500 words*	Definition and justification of the research methodology	*Outline and justify the chosen methodology*	☐ Yes ☐ No	
	Background information about the context of your study (optional)	*Present the context in which your study was conducted (e.g. geography)*	☐ Yes ☐ No	
	Sample and sampling techniques + ethical considerations (if human/animal subjects)	*Outline who or what you studied, how you got it, and any ethical considerations (if human/animal subjects)*	☐ Yes ☐ No	
	Research tools and procedures	*Specify which research tools you used and*	☐ Yes ☐ No	

Section	Element	Purpose	In my field?	My notes and ideas
		specifically how you conducted your study		
	Data analysis techniques	*Present how you analyzed your data and justify your choice*	☐ Yes ☐ No	
Results *1500 – 3000 words*	Presentation of the main results	*Present the results you obtained*	☐ Yes ☐ No	
	Clear use of tables, figures or quotes from participants	*Provide a visual representation of the data and raw evidence*	☐ Yes ☐ No	
Discussion *500 – 1000 words*	Restatement of the result to be discussed	*Remind the reader of the result*	☐ Yes ☐ No	
	Comparison of the result with the literature	*Situate the result within the literature context*	☐ Yes ☐ No	
	Explanation of the findings and/or differences with literature	*Explain the findings you obtained and possible differences with previous studies*	☐ Yes ☐ No	
	Interpretation of the findings	*Show what your findings mean and how they can be understood*	☐ Yes ☐ No	
Conclusion *500 – 1000 words*	Restatement of the main aim and topic	*Remind the reader of the aim and topic of your study*	☐ Yes ☐ No	
	Recap of the key findings and contributions + a brief discussion	*Restate the main results and discuss briefly*	☐ Yes ☐ No	
	Practical implications of the findings	*Show what impact your findings can have for different stakeholders*	☐ Yes ☐ No	
	Limitations	*Acknowledge the limitations of your study*	☐ Yes ☐ No	
	Suggestions for future research	*Suggest what future research should focus on*	☐ Yes ☐ No	